‘*mujtahid*’ considered wise enough to interpret Islamic law. Akbar, besides, was ‘a most just, a most wise, and a most God-fearing king’ and therefore, the ulema went on, Akbar should have the final say in any future disputes between scholars and jurists of Islam in his realm. Not only that, the ulema vowed to ‘be bound’ by any new orders that Akbar issued; refusal – as befits Akbar’s straddling of two realms – would invite both ‘damnation in the world to come’, and ‘loss of property and religious privileges in this’.[18]

In effect, it was an utter rout. Abul Fazl has Akbar offering coy refusals while the ulema falls ‘to entreaty’, but surely the real reluctance was on the side of the clerics. Amongst them were poor Abdun Nabi and Makhdum-ul-Mulk, now wretched in the shadow of Shaikh Mubarak’s increasing heft. All of them, writes Badauni, ‘signed it against their will’; except, of course, Shaikh Mubarak, who even added an eager postscript to his signature, saying that ‘he most willingly signed his name; for this was a matter to which for several years he had been anxiously looking forward’.

It wasn’t just the meaning of the mahzar that would have troubled the ulema, but also its language. Shaikh Mubarak had proclaimed Akbar ‘the imam of the time and the mujtahid of the age’. As Wheeler M. Thackston explains it in his translation of the *Akbarnama*, ‘imam’ would refer to the Shiite belief in successive descendants of the Prophet Muhammad sent to earth to lead the Muslim world; while ‘mujtahid’, an interpreter of Islamic law, was an office considered unnecessary by Sunni jurisprudence, which favoured precedence over interpretation. In assuming these titles, therefore, Akbar was ‘[a]pparently determined to offend everyone’ – both Shias and Sunnis would consider his claim controversial, if not downright heretical.[19]

Iqtidar Alam Khan[20] argues for a rather different interpretation of the mahzar’s meaning. Is it not a little odd, he asks, that Abul Fazl, whose own father drafted the mahzar, doesn’t include a copy of it in the *Akbarnama*? We have it via Badauni. Abul Fazl only provides a summary, and a misleading summary at that, ‘creat[ing] the impression that the mahzar declared the king’s role to be that of an arbitrator’ between quarrelling jurists, whereas, in fact, it proposed Akbar as the ‘sole head of the orthodox Muslims of India’[21] – it did not mean to offend them but to bring them into the ambit of Akbar’s authority.

Why would Abul Fazl downplay the mahzar’s meaning? Possibly, writes